

BALANCE TIPPED Marina Beach, Chennai, after it was hit by a tsunami, Dec. 2004

AFP

Earthquakes, cyclones, tsunamis—times when the grim reaper slips through the cracks of even the most rigorous 21st century warning systems—defined the decade between 1995 and 2005, when walls of water slammed Indian coasts, whirls of wind gobbled towns, and subterranean land-shuffling drummed up enough shell-shocked memories to fill a small library with obituaries and doomsday prophecies.

The period started off ominously: the ghastliest toll was exacted from India's neighbour, Nepal, when the remnants of a cyclone reached the Himalayas and caused a snowstorm that trapped hundreds for days. India was to get the big one—off the coast of Odisha—just months before the new millennium. A five-day ordeal whose fatalities are still uncertainly numbered—anywhere from 10,000 to 30,000—it took a while for the displaced millions to get back to that 150 sq. km strip of coastland. Never again, said Odisha, and set to work.

Soon after, Mumbai slum-dwellers almost exclusively bore the brunt of a landslide in 2000 that continues to inform the municipality's disaster preparedness. Next year's earthquake in Gujarat killed 20,000 and injured hundreds of thousands in a several minutes-long tectonic grind that felled buildings like ninepins. Combine that with the double-whammy of the 2004 earthquake-tsunami, the event shattering records of devastation and permanently raising global sea levels by 0.1 mm, and you perhaps witnessed a lifetime's worth of what happens when, in writer George Saunders's words, "the big something...innocently moves. It crushes people". ■



Odisha: When Hope Died
Nov. 15, 1999



Killer Wave
Jan. 10, 2005

THREE CYCLONES, AN URBAN LANDSLIDE AND A MAMMOTH EARTHQUAKE-TSUNAMI IN THIS DECADE REMAIN ETCHED IN INDIA'S MEMORY